



DEFENCE ASPIRANT'S COMPREHENSIVE HANDBOOK

For SSB Interviews & Defence Written Examinations

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1. STATES AND CAPITALS OF INDIA

India has 28 states. The following table lists each state along with its capital city.

S.No	State	Capital
1	Andhra Pradesh	Amaravati
2	Arunachal Pradesh	Itanagar
3	Assam	Dispur
4	Bihar	Patna
5	Chhattisgarh	Raipur
6	Goa	Panaji
7	Gujarat	Gandhinagar
8	Haryana	Chandigarh
9	Himachal Pradesh	Shimla
10	Jharkhand	Ranchi
11	Karnataka	Bengaluru
12	Kerala	Thiruvananthapuram
13	Madhya Pradesh	Bhopal
14	Maharashtra	Mumbai
15	Manipur	Imphal
16	Meghalaya	Shillong
17	Mizoram	Aizawl
18	Nagaland	Kohima
19	Odisha	Bhubaneswar
20	Punjab	Chandigarh
21	Rajasthan	Jaipur
22	Sikkim	Gangtok
23	Tamil Nadu	Chennai
24	Telangana	Hyderabad
25	Tripura	Agartala
26	Uttar Pradesh	Lucknow
27	Uttarakhand	Dehradun (Winter) / Gairsain (Summer)
28	West Bengal	Kolkata

Note: Uttarakhand uses Dehradun as winter capital and Gairsain (Bhararisain) as the legislative (summer) capital.

2. UNION TERRITORIES AND CAPITALS

India has 8 Union Territories directly administered by the Central Government.

S.No	Union Territory	Capital / Headquarters
1	Andaman and Nicobar Islands	Port Blair
2	Chandigarh	Chandigarh
3	Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu	Daman
4	Delhi (NCT)	New Delhi
5	Jammu and Kashmir	Srinagar (Summer) / Jammu (Winter)
6	Ladakh	Leh
7	Lakshadweep	Kavaratti
8	Puducherry	Puducherry

Note: J&K became a UT (without legislature) after abrogation of Article 370 on 5 August 2019. Ladakh is a UT without a legislature.

3. INDIAN ARMY COMMANDS AND HEADQUARTERS

The Indian Army is organised into 7 commands, each headed by a General Officer Commanding-in-Chief (GOC-in-C) of Lieutenant General rank.

Command	Headquarters	Area of Responsibility
Northern Command	Udhampur, J&K	Entire J&K, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh
Western Command	Chandimandir, Haryana	Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan (part)
South Western Command	Jaipur, Rajasthan	Rajasthan, Gujarat
Southern Command	Pune, Maharashtra	Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, MP
Central Command	Lucknow, UP	UP, Uttarakhand, Bihar, Jharkhand, MP (part)
Eastern Command	Kolkata, WB	WB, Sikkim, Assam, NE States
Army Training Command (ARTRAC)	Shimla, HP	Training establishments across India

Note: Army Training Command (ARTRAC) is the 7th command focused on training rather than operational area.

4. INDIAN NAVY COMMANDS AND HEADQUARTERS

The Indian Navy is organised into 3 commands, each headed by a Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief (FOC-in-C) of Vice Admiral rank.

Command	Headquarters	Remarks
Western Naval Command	Mumbai	Arabian Sea operations; Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief
Eastern Naval Command	Visakhapatnam	Bay of Bengal operations; Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief
Southern Naval Command	Kochi, Kerala	Training Command; Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief

Note: The Andaman and Nicobar Command (ANC) at Port Blair is a Tri-Service Command jointly administered by Army, Navy and IAF.

5. INDIAN AIR FORCE COMMANDS AND HEADQUARTERS

The Indian Air Force has 7 commands. Operational commands handle combat readiness; Maintenance and Training commands provide support.

Command	Headquarters	Area / Role
Western Air Command	New Delhi	Punjab, Haryana, J&K, HP, UP (part)
South Western Air Command	Gandhinagar, Gujarat	Rajasthan, Gujarat, Maharashtra (part)
Southern Air Command	Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala	Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Goa, A&N Islands
Central Air Command	Prayagraj (Allahabad), UP	UP, Uttarakhand, Bihar, MP, Jharkhand
Eastern Air Command	Shillong, Meghalaya	NE States, WB, Sikkim, Odisha (part)
Maintenance Command	Nagpur, Maharashtra	Logistics & maintenance of all IAF assets
Training Command	Bengaluru, Karnataka	All IAF training establishments

Note: Western Air Command is the most operationally active, covering the capital and Pakistan / China borders.

6. MILITARY RANKS

6.1 Indian Army – Officer Ranks

Rank	Role / Command	Star Level	Insignia
Field Marshal	Highest ceremonial rank (5-star)		

Rank	Role / Command	Star Level	Insignia
General	Chief of Army Staff (COAS)	4-star	
Lieutenant General	Army Commanders, Corps Commanders	3-star	
Major General	Division Commander	2-star	
Brigadier	Brigade Commander	1-star	
Colonel	Battalion/Regiment CO		
Lieutenant Colonel	Battalion 2IC / CO		
Major	Company Commander / Staff Officer		

Rank	Role / Command	Star Level	Insignia
Captain	Platoon Commander		
Lieutenant	Entry level rank after commissioning		

6.2 Indian Army – Junior Commissioned Officers (JCO)

JCO Rank	Role	Insignia
Subedar Major	Senior JCO Highest Non-Commissioned Rank	
Subedar	Second JCO rank	
Naib Subedar	Junior JCO rank	

6.3 Indian Army – Other Ranks (OR) / Soldiers

Rank	Role
Havildar Major	Senior NCO in unit
Havildar	Section 2IC
Naik	Fire Team Leader
Lance Naik	Junior NCO
Sepoy	Basic soldier rank

6.4 Indian Navy – Officer Ranks

Rank	Equivalent Role	Insignia
Admiral of the Fleet	Honorary 5-star rank	
Admiral	Chief of Naval Staff (CNS)	
Vice Admiral	Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief / Fleet Commander	
Rear Admiral	Senior Flag Rank	
Commodore	Flotilla Commander	
Captain	Ship Commanding Officer	
Commander	Senior Officer	
Lieutenant Commander	Mid-level Officer	
Lieutenant	Junior Officer	
Sub Lieutenant	Entry level after training	



6.5 Indian Navy – Sailor Ranks

Rank	Role
Master Chief Petty Officer 1st Class	Senior Sailor rank
Master Chief Petty Officer 2nd Class	Senior Sailor
Chief Petty Officer	Division Chief
Petty Officer	Senior Rating

Rank	Role
Leading Seaman	Section Leader
Seaman I	Basic Rating
Seaman II / Recruit	Entry Level

6.6 Indian Air Force – Officer Ranks

Rank	Equivalent Role	Insignia
Marshal of the Air Force	Honorary 5-star rank	
Air Chief Marshal	Chief of Air Staff (CAS)	
Air Marshal	Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief	
Air Vice Marshal	Senior Air Flag Rank	
Air Commodore	Senior Air Officer	
Group Captain	Wing / Base CO	
Wing Commander	Squadron CO	
Squadron Leader	Flight Commander	
Flight Lieutenant	Pilot / Officer	
Flying Officer	Junior Officer	

6.7 Indian Air Force – Airmen Ranks

Rank	Role
Master Warrant Officer	Senior JCO equivalent
Warrant Officer	JCO equivalent
Junior Warrant Officer	Junior JCO equivalent
Sergeant	Senior NCO
Corporal	NCO
Leading Aircraftman	Senior Airman
Aircraftman	Entry Level Airman

7. IMPORTANT MILITARY EXERCISES

India regularly conducts bilateral and multilateral military exercises to enhance interoperability, share best practices, and strengthen strategic partnerships.

Exercise Name	Countries Involved	Type	Frequency
Yudh Abhyas	India – USA	Army	Alternate India/USA
Vajra Prahar	India – USA	Special Forces	Alternate India/USA
Cope India	India – USA	Air Force	Alternate India/USA
Indra	India – Russia	Tri-Service	Alternate India/Russia
Aviandra	India – Russia	Air Force	Alternate India/Russia
Shakti	India – France	Army	Biennial
Garuda	India – France	Air Force	Biennial
Varuna	India – France	Navy	Annual
Tarkash	India – France	Special Forces	Periodic
Surya Kiran	India – Nepal	Army	Annual
Maitree	India – Thailand	Army	Biennial
Garuda Shakti	India – Indonesia	Special Forces	Biennial
Dharma Guardian	India – Japan	Army	Annual
JIMEX	India – Japan	Navy	Biennial
SLINEX	India – Sri Lanka	Navy	Annual
Mitra Shakti	India – Sri Lanka	Army	Annual
Sampriti	India – Bangladesh	Army	Biennial
Hand in Hand	India – China	Army	Biennial
Nomadic Elephant	India – Mongolia	Army	Annual
Shakti (Bold Kurukshetra)	India – Singapore	Army	Annual

Exercise Name	Countries Involved	Type	Frequency
Malabar	India – USA – Japan	Navy	Annual
TROPEX	India (Internal)	Navy	Biennial (Theatre exercise)
Iron Fist	India (Internal)	Air Force	Periodic
Tasman Saber	India – Australia – USA	Tri-Service	Periodic
Desert Eagle	India – UAE	Air Force	Periodic
Red Flag	India – USA (Alaska)	Air Force	Periodic
Dustlik	India – Uzbekistan	Army	Annual
Ajeya Warrior	India – UK	Army	Biennial
KAZIND	India – Kazakhstan	Army	Annual

8. DEFENCE TRAINING ACADEMIES

India has a robust network of defence training institutions producing officers and personnel for the Army, Navy, Air Force and paramilitary forces.

Academy	Location	Service	Purpose
National Defence Academy (NDA)	Khadakwasla, Pune, Maharashtra	Tri-Service	Officers' pre-commission training (10+2 entry) for Army, Navy, IAF
Indian Military Academy (IMA)	Dehradun, Uttarakhand	Army	Pre-commission training for Gentlemen Cadets
Officers Training Academy (OTA)	Chennai, Tamil Nadu	Army	Short Service Commission (SSC) and Women Military Police training
Indian Naval Academy (INA)	Ezhimala, Kannur, Kerala	Navy	Pre-commission training for naval officers
Air Force Academy (AFA)	Dundigal, Hyderabad, Telangana	Air Force	Pre-commission flying and ground training for IAF officers
National Defence College (NDC)	New Delhi	Tri-Service	Senior leadership course (Maj Gen / equivalent and above)
Defence Services Staff College (DSSC)	Wellington, Tamil Nadu	Tri-Service	Staff Course for Lt Col equivalent officers
College of Defence Management (CDM)	Secunderabad, Telangana	Tri-Service	Management education for senior officers
Army War College (AWC)	Mhow, Madhya Pradesh	Army	Higher Command Course for senior officers
College of Military Engineering (CME)	Pune, Maharashtra	Army / Corps of Engineers	Technical military engineering training

Academy	Location	Service	Purpose
Military College of Telecommunication Engineering (MCTE)	Mhow, Madhya Pradesh	Army (Corps of Signals)	Telecom and IT training
Armed Forces Medical College (AFMC)	Pune, Maharashtra	Tri-Service (Medical)	Medical officer training and MBBS
Rashtriya Indian Military College (RIMC)	Dehradun, Uttarakhand	Tri-Service	Feeder institution for NDA (Class 8–12)
Sainik Schools	Various (33 schools across India)	Tri-Service	Feeder schools for NDA (Class 6 entry)
Rashtriya Military School (RMS)	Ajmer, Belgaum, Bengaluru, Chail, Dholpur	Army	Feeder schools for NDA

9. PARAM VIR CHAKRA AWARDEES

The **Param Vir Chakra (PVC)** is India's highest wartime gallantry award, instituted on 26 January 1950. The decoration was designed by Savitri Khanolkar. A total of **21 PVCs** have been awarded, of which 14 were posthumous.

Name / Rank	Regiment / Service	War / Year	Key Action
Maj Somnath Sharma	4th Btn Kumaon Regt	1947 (J&K)	Posthumous – Battle of Badgam, 3 Nov 1947
L/Nk Karam Singh	1st Btn Sikh Regt	1947 (J&K)	Battle of Tithwal; First living PVC recipient
2nd Lt Rama Raghoba Rane	Corps of Engineers	1948 (J&K)	Mine clearance under fire near Naushera
Nk Jadunath Singh	1st Btn Rajput Regt	1947 (J&K)	Posthumous – Naushera, 6 Feb 1948
Coy Hav Maj Piru Singh	6th Btn Rajputana Rifles	1948 (J&K)	Posthumous – Tithwal
Capt G.S. Salaria	3rd Btn Gorkha Rifles	1961 (Congo)	Posthumous – Only PVC in UN operations
Maj Dhan Singh Thapa	1st Sikh Btn	1962 (Sino-Indian War)	Rezang La / Ladakh sector
Sub Joginder Singh	1st Btn Sikh Regt	1962 (Sino-Indian War)	Posthumous – Tongpen La, NEFA
Maj Shaitan Singh	13th Btn Kumaon Regt	1962 (Sino-Indian War)	Posthumous – Rezang La
CQMH Abdul Hamid	4th Btn Grenadiers	1965 (Pakistan War)	Posthumous – Cheema, Khem Karan sector
Lt Col A.B. Tarapore	Poona Horse	1965 (Pakistan War)	Posthumous – Phillora, Sialkot sector

Name / Rank	Regiment / Service	War / Year	Key Action
L/Nk Albert Ekka	14th Btn Guards	1971 (Bangladesh Liberation)	Posthumous – Gangasagar
Fg Off Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon	18 Squadron IAF	1971 (Bangladesh Liberation)	Posthumous – Srinagar air base; only IAF PVC
2nd Lt Arun Khetarpal	Poona Horse	1971 (Bangladesh Liberation)	Posthumous – Basantar; youngest PVC officer
Maj Hoshiyar Singh	3rd Btn Grenadiers	1971 (Bangladesh Liberation)	Basantar River crossing
Nb Sub Bana Singh	8th Btn JAK Light Infantry	1987 (Siachen)	Quaid Post recapture at Siachen
Maj R. Parameswaran	8th Mahar Regt	1987 (Sri Lanka / IPKF)	Posthumous – Batticaloa, Sri Lanka
Capt Vikram Batra	13th Btn JAK Rifles	1999 (Kargil)	Posthumous – Point 4875; 'Yeh Dil Maange More'
Lt Manoj Kumar Pandey	1st Btn 11 Gorkha Rifles	1999 (Kargil)	Posthumous – Khalubar, Batalik sector
Rfn Sanjay Kumar	13th Btn JAK Rifles	1999 (Kargil)	Flat Top, Area Flats, Kargil
Gren Yogender Singh Yadav	18th Btn Grenadiers	1999 (Kargil)	Tiger Hill assault, Kargil

Note: Flying Officer Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon is the only IAF officer to receive the PVC. Capt G.S. Salaria is the only PVC awardee in UN peacekeeping operations.

10. GALLANTRY AWARDS

India's gallantry awards are classified into wartime awards (for bravery against an enemy) and peacetime awards (for bravery in other circumstances).

Award	Category	Eligibility	Citation Standard
Param Vir Chakra (PVC)	Wartime – Highest	All three services	Most conspicuous bravery or sacrifice in presence of the enemy
Maha Vir Chakra (MVC)	Wartime – 2nd Highest	All three services	Acts of conspicuous gallantry in presence of the enemy
Vir Chakra (VrC)	Wartime – 3rd Highest	All three services	Acts of bravery in presence of the enemy
Ashok Chakra (AC)	Peacetime – Highest	All three services & civilians	Conspicuous gallantry / sacrifice away from battlefield

Award	Category	Eligibility	Citation Standard
Kirti Chakra (KC)	Peacetime – 2nd Highest	All three services & civilians	Conspicuous gallantry
Shaurya Chakra (SC)	Peacetime – 3rd Highest	All three services & civilians	Gallantry and daring
Sena Medal	Peacetime / Wartime	Army	Individual act of special service / gallantry
Nao Sena Medal	Peacetime / Wartime	Navy	Individual act of special service / gallantry
Vayu Sena Medal	Peacetime / Wartime	Air Force	Individual act of special service / gallantry
Param Vishisht Seva Medal (PVSM)	Peacetime	All three services	Most distinguished service
Ati Vishisht Seva Medal (AVSM)	Peacetime	All three services	Distinguished service
Vishisht Seva Medal (VSM)	Peacetime	All three services	Valuable service
Chief of Army/Navy/Air Force Staff Commendation Card	Peacetime	Respective service	Service-level commendation

Hierarchy (Wartime): PVC > MVC > VrC | Hierarchy (Peacetime): Ashok Chakra > Kirti Chakra > Shaurya Chakra

11. HIGHEST CIVILIAN AWARDS

India's civilian honours recognise distinguished service, exceptional achievements, and outstanding contributions to the nation across various fields including defence, science, arts, social service, and sports.

Award	Hierarchy / Type	Criteria
Bharat Ratna	Highest civilian honour of India	Exceptional service / highest order of merit in any field
Padma Vibhushan	Second highest civilian honour	Exceptional and distinguished service
Padma Bhushan	Third highest civilian honour	Distinguished service of a high order
Padma Shri	Fourth civilian honour	Distinguished service in any field
Jeevan Raksha Padak	Civilian gallantry – saving life	Awarded for saving human life at personal risk
Rashtrapati's Police Medal for Gallantry	Police / paramilitary	Acts of gallantry in line of duty
Kirti Chakra / Shaurya Chakra	Military + Civilians	Also awarded to civilians in anti-insurgency / counter-terrorism

Award	Hierarchy / Type	Criteria
Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna	Sports – Highest	Spectacular / most outstanding performance in sports
Dronacharya Award	Sports – Coaching	Excellence in coaching
Arjuna Award	Sports – Performance	Outstanding performance in sports

Note: The Bharat Ratna is the highest civilian honour of India. It is not restricted to citizens and has been awarded to foreign nationals (Nelson Mandela, 1990; Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan, 1987). The award does not carry any monetary grant.

12. IMPORTANT DEFENCE ORGANISATIONS

India's defence industrial base consists of Defence Public Sector Undertakings (DPSUs), research organisations, and regulatory bodies. The Ordnance Factories Board (OFB) was dissolved in 2021 and its units reorganised into 7 DPSUs.

Abbr.	Full Name	Headquarters	Primary Role
DRDO	Defence Research & Development Organisation	New Delhi	R&D for defence technologies; 50+ laboratories
HAL	Hindustan Aeronautics Limited	Bengaluru	Aircraft, helicopters, aero-engines manufacturing
BEL	Bharat Electronics Limited	Bengaluru	Electronic defence systems, radars, communication
BEML	Bharat Earth Movers Limited	Bengaluru	Heavy vehicles, metro rail, defence equipment
MDL	Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited	Mumbai	Warships and submarines
GRSE	Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers	Kolkata	Warships and deck machinery
GSL	Goa Shipyard Limited	Goa	Patrol vessels, offshore vessels
MIDHANI	Mishra Dhatu Nigam Limited	Hyderabad	Special steels, titanium, super alloys
AVNL	Armoured Vehicles Nigam Limited	Chennai	Tanks, infantry combat vehicles
MIL	Munitions India Limited	Pune	Ammunition and explosives
YANTRA India	Yantra India Limited	Jabalpur	Ordnance factories / artillery systems
AWE India	Advanced Weapons & Equipment India Ltd	Kanpur	Small arms and advanced weapons
GIL	Gliders India Limited	Kanpur	Personal protective gear, parachutes

Abbr.	Full Name	Headquarters	Primary Role
TCL	Troop Comforts Limited	Kolkata	Canteen stores and troop welfare items
India Optel	India Optel Limited	Dehradun	Optical instruments and night vision devices
ARDE	Armament Research & Dev. Establishment	Pune	Armament systems (under DRDO)
CABS	Centre for Airborne Systems	Bengaluru	Airborne surveillance (under DRDO)
SAG	Scientific Analysis Group	New Delhi	Crypto & information security (DRDO)
DPP/DAP	Defence Acquisition Procedure	New Delhi	Policy for procurement of defence equipment
CDS HQ	HQ Integrated Defence Staff	New Delhi	Chief of Defence Staff office and tri-service integration

13. DRDO LABORATORIES

The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), under the Ministry of Defence, operates 52+ laboratories across India. Key laboratories are listed below by domain.

Lab Code	Full Name	Location	Focus Area
DRDL	Defence Research & Development Laboratory	Hyderabad	Missiles – Agni, Prithvi, BrahMos support
ASL	Advanced Systems Laboratory	Hyderabad	Long-range strategic missiles (Agni-V etc.)
RCI	Research Centre Imarat	Hyderabad	Missile seekers, guidance & control systems
DMRL	Defence Metallurgical Research Laboratory	Hyderabad	Special metals for aerospace & defence
GTRE	Gas Turbine Research Establishment	Bengaluru	Kaveri jet engine; aero-engines
ADE	Aeronautical Development Establishment	Bengaluru	Tejas support, UAVs (Rustom), Lakshya
DARE	Defence Avionics Research Establishment	Bengaluru	Avionics & electronic warfare systems
LRDE	Electronics & Radar Development Establishment	Bengaluru	Radars – Arudhra, Ashwini, Aakashteer
CAIR	Centre for AI & Robotics	Bengaluru	AI, robotics, autonomous systems

Lab Code	Full Name	Location	Focus Area
CABS	Centre for Airborne Systems	Bengaluru	AEW&C systems (Netra AWACS)
ARDE	Armament Research & Development Establishment	Pune	Small arms, artillery (Dhanush), bombs
HEMRL	High Energy Materials Research Laboratory	Pune	Explosives, propellants, pyrotechnics
CFEES	Centre for Fire, Explosive & Environment Safety	New Delhi	Fire safety, chemical & nuclear defence
INMAS	Institute of Nuclear Medicine & Allied Sciences	New Delhi	Nuclear medicine, radiation biology
DIPAS	Defence Institute of Physiology & Allied Sciences	New Delhi	High-altitude and extreme environment physiology
DESIDOC	Defence Scientific Info & Documentation Centre	New Delhi	Defence knowledge management
SSPL	Solid State Physics Laboratory	New Delhi	Semiconductors, sensor materials
SAG	Scientific Analysis Group	New Delhi	Cryptology and information security
TBRL	Terminal Ballistics Research Laboratory	Chandigarh	Weapons testing, ballistics
SASE	Snow & Avalanche Study Establishment	Chandigarh	Avalanche prediction, cold-region research
IRDE	Instruments Research & Development Establishment	Dehradun	Optical & opto-electronic instruments
NPOL	Naval Physical & Oceanographic Laboratory	Kochi	Underwater acoustics, sonar systems
NSTL	Naval Science & Technological Laboratory	Visakhapatnam	Underwater weapons (torpedoes), AUVs
NMRL	Naval Materials Research Laboratory	Ambernath	Marine corrosion, special coatings
SAC (DRDO)	Space Applications for Defence	Bengaluru	Defence satellite payloads
MTRDC	Microwave Tube Research & Development Centre	Bengaluru	High-power microwave tubes
DLRL	Defence Electronics Research Laboratory	Hyderabad	Electronic warfare, ESM/ECM systems
DEBEL	Defence Bioengineering & Electromedical Lab	Bengaluru	Life-support systems, aircrew equipment
DIHAR	Defence Institute of High-Altitude Research	Leh	Agriculture & animal husbandry at high altitude
DIBER	Defence Institute of Bio-Energy Research	Haldwani, UK	Bio-energy, hemp fibre research

14. BORDERING COUNTRIES OF INDIA

India shares land borders with 6 countries and maritime boundaries with 2 island nations. The total land border length is approximately 15,106 km.

Country	Direction	Border Length	Indian States Bordering
Pakistan	Northwest / West	3,323 km	Punjab, Rajasthan, Gujarat, J&K
China (PRC)	North / Northeast	3,488 km	Ladakh, HP, Uttarakhand, Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh
Nepal	North	1,751 km	Uttarakhand, UP, Bihar, West Bengal, Sikkim
Bhutan	Northeast	699 km	Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, WB
Bangladesh	East	4,156 km	WB, Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura, Mizoram
Myanmar	East	1,643 km	Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram
Sri Lanka	South	Maritime boundary (~65 km Palk Strait)	Tamil Nadu coast
Afghanistan	Northwest	106 km (via PoK – disputed)	Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir region
Maldives	South	Maritime boundary (Arabian Sea)	Lakshadweep region

Longest land border: Bangladesh (4,156 km). Shortest: Afghanistan (106 km via PoK). India shares the longest coastline on mainland with Andhra Pradesh.

15. INTERNATIONAL BORDERS AND THEIR NAMES

Several of India's borders have specific names or designations that are frequently asked in defence examinations. Understanding their strategic significance is essential.

Border Name	Countries Separated	Key Facts
Radcliffe Line	India – Pakistan & India – Bangladesh	Demarcated in 1947 during Partition by Sir Cyril Radcliffe; defines official international boundary
Line of Control (LoC)	India – Pakistan (J&K)	De facto border in J&K/Jammu & Kashmir since 1972 Shimla Agreement; not an international border
Line of Actual Control (LAC)	India – China	De facto border; divided into Western (Ladakh), Middle (HP/UK), Eastern (Arunachal) sectors; ~3,488 km

Border Name	Countries Separated	Key Facts
McMahon Line	India – China (Arunachal Pradesh)	1914 Simla Convention boundary; India accepts, China disputes; forms eastern section of LAC
Durand Line	Pakistan – Afghanistan	1893 colonial boundary; disputed by Afghanistan; affects PoK region near India
Actual Ground Position Line (AGPL)	India – Pakistan (Siachen)	Extends the LoC northward; India controls Siachen Glacier; not formally agreed
International Boundary (IB)	India – Pakistan (plains)	Recognised international border in Jammu, Punjab & Rajasthan sectors
Working Boundary	India – Pakistan (Jammu sector)	Claimed as international border by Pakistan but termed Working Boundary by India
India – Nepal	Open Border (Treaty of Peace and Friendship 1950)	Sugauli Treaty 1815 basis; no visa required for movement
India – Bhutan	Open Border (Friendship Treaty 1949/2007)	Free movement; India handles Bhutan's external defence

16. IMPORTANT MOUNTAIN PASSES

Mountain passes (ghati or la) are strategically vital for military logistics, supply lines, and as chokepoints during conflicts. Many are key to India's defence architecture in the Himalayas and Karakoram.

Pass Name	State / Region	Altitude	Strategic Significance
Zoji La	J&K / Ladakh	3,528 m	Connects Srinagar to Leh (NH-1); strategic pass on NW-1
Khardung La	Ladakh	5,359 m	Nubra Valley access; historically claimed as highest motorable road
Chang La	Ladakh	5,360 m	Leads to Pangong Tso lake area; strategically vital
Tanglang La	Ladakh	5,328 m	On Leh-Manali Highway
Baralacha La (Bara Lacha)	Himachal Pradesh – Ladakh	4,890 m	Connects Manali to Leh; Manali-Leh Highway
Rohtang Pass	Himachal Pradesh	3,978 m	Manali–Spiti/Lahaul; now bypassed by Atal Tunnel
Shipki La	Himachal Pradesh – China	5,669 m	India-China trade route on Sutlej river valley
Nathu La	Sikkim – China	4,310 m	India-China trade route; re-opened in 2006 after 44 years
Jelep La	Sikkim – China	4,267 m	Historical Kalimpong-Lhasa trade route; currently closed

Pass Name	State / Region	Altitude	Strategic Significance
Bum La	Arunachal Pradesh – China	4,700 m	Tawang sector; historically sensitive
Sela Pass	Arunachal Pradesh	4,170 m	Connects Tezpur to Tawang; key military supply route
Lipulekh Pass	Uttarakhand – China (Nepal trijunction)	5,334 m	Kailash Mansarovar yatra route; disputed with Nepal
Mana Pass	Uttarakhand – China	5,545 m	Near Badrinath; ancient trade and pilgrimage route
Niti Pass	Uttarakhand – China	5,389 m	Chamoli district; historical trade route
Marsimik La	Ladakh	5,590 m	Near Pangong Tso; among highest continuously used passes

Note: 'La' in Tibetan/Ladakhi means 'pass'. Khardung La was earlier (incorrectly) claimed as highest motorable road in the world. Umling La (Ladakh, 19,024 ft) is now recognised as the world's highest motorable road.

17. IMPORTANT RIVERS AND DAMS

Major dams serve multiple purposes: irrigation, hydroelectric power generation, flood control, and water supply. Many are strategically significant for national security and economic development.

Dam Name	River	State	Key Fact
Bhakra Nangal Dam	Sutlej River	Himachal Pradesh / Punjab border	Highest gravity dam in Asia (226 m); Govind Sagar reservoir
Tehri Dam	Bhagirathi River	Uttarakhand	Highest dam in India (260 m); 4th tallest in world; Tehri reservoir
Sardar Sarovar Dam	Narmada River	Gujarat (Kevadiya)	Largest concrete dam in India; Statue of Unity nearby
Hirakud Dam	Mahanadi River	Odisha (Sambalpur)	Longest earthen dam in world (26 km); first post-Independence dam
Indira Sagar Dam	Narmada River	Madhya Pradesh	Largest reservoir capacity in India
Nagarjuna Sagar Dam	Krishna River	Telangana / Andhra Pradesh	World's largest masonry dam at time of construction
Tungabhadra Dam	Tungabhadra River	Karnataka (Hospet)	Serves Karnataka & Andhra Pradesh
Koyna Dam	Koyna River	Maharashtra	Largest hydroelectric project in Maharashtra

Dam Name	River	State	Key Fact
Farakka Barrage	Ganga River	West Bengal	Diverts Ganga water to Hooghly; water-sharing with Bangladesh
Rihand Dam	Rihand River (Son tributary)	Uttar Pradesh	Govind Ballabh Pant Sagar – largest artificial lake in India (area)
Idukki Dam	Periyar River	Kerala	Highest arch dam in India; 168.5 m
Mettur Dam	Cauvery River	Tamil Nadu (Salem)	Stanley Reservoir; key irrigation dam of Tamil Nadu
Krishnaraja Sagar (KRS) Dam	Cauvery River	Karnataka (Mandya)	Primary source for Bengaluru & Mysuru water
Kabini Dam	Kabini River (Kaveri trib.)	Karnataka	Multipurpose; key for Mysuru district
Srisaillam Dam	Krishna River	Telangana / Andhra Pradesh	2nd largest hydroelectric plant in India

Highest Dam: Tehri (260 m) | Longest Dam: Hirakud (26 km) | First Post-Independence Dam: Hirakud | Largest Reservoir (capacity): Indira Sagar | Largest Reservoir (area): Gobind Ballabh Pant (Rihand)

18. IMPORTANT PORTS AND NAVAL BASES

India has 13 Major Ports (under central government) and 200+ minor/intermediate ports (under state governments). The Navy maintains strategic bases along both coastlines and island territories.

18.1 Major Seaports

Port Name	State	Coast / Location	Significance
Mumbai Port (BPT)	Maharashtra	West Coast – Arabian Sea	One of oldest & busiest natural harbours
JNPT (Jawaharlal Nehru Port)	Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra	West Coast	India's largest container port
Deendayal Port (Kandla)	Gujarat	West Coast – Gulf of Kutch	Largest port by cargo volume; renamed from Kandla
New Mangalore Port	Karnataka	West Coast	Key liquid cargo and container port
Mormugao Port	Goa	West Coast	Iron ore export hub
Cochin Port	Kerala	West Coast – Laccadive Sea	Natural harbour; major gateway for SW India

Port Name	State	Coast / Location	Significance
Chennai Port	Tamil Nadu	East Coast – Bay of Bengal	Oldest artificial port; 2nd busiest container port
V.O. Chidambaranar Port (Tuticorin)	Tamil Nadu	East Coast	Coal & container hub
Kamarajar Port (Ennore)	Tamil Nadu	East Coast	Coal & LNG; India's only corporatised major port
Visakhapatnam Port	Andhra Pradesh	East Coast	Deepest port on east coast; natural harbour
Paradip Port	Odisha	East Coast	Iron ore and coal; key Odisha gateway
Kolkata Port (Syama Prasad Mookerjee)	West Bengal	River Port – Hooghly	Oldest operating port; also includes Haldia Dock

18.2 Key Naval Bases and Establishments

Establishment	State / Location	Command	Significance
INS Kadamba (Project Seabird)	Karwar, Karnataka	Western Naval Command	Largest naval base in India (under expansion)
INS Hansa	Vasco da Gama, Goa	Western Naval Command	Naval Air Station Goa
INS Shikra	Mumbai, Maharashtra	Western Naval Command	Naval Air Station Mumbai
INS Hamla	Malad, Mumbai	Western Naval Command	Logistics & Supply establishment
INS Valsura	Jamnagar, Gujarat	Western Naval Command	Electrical & weapons training school
INS Garuda	Kochi, Kerala	Southern Naval Command	Naval Air Station Kochi; HQ Southern Command
INS Venduruthy	Kochi, Kerala	Southern Naval Command	Naval base and training establishment
INS Chilika	Chilika, Odisha	Eastern Naval Command	Sailor recruitment training centre
INS Dega	Visakhapatnam, AP	Eastern Naval Command	Naval Air Station Visakhapatnam; ENC HQ area
INS Circars	Visakhapatnam, AP	Eastern Naval Command	Key shore establishment ENC
INS Rajali	Arakkonam, Tamil Nadu	Southern Naval Command	Largest naval air station in Asia

Establishment	State / Location	Command	Significance
INS Baaz	Campbell Bay, A&N Islands	Andaman & Nicobar Command	Southernmost naval air station of India
INS Kohassa	Diglipur, A&N Islands	Andaman & Nicobar Command	Northernmost naval air station of India
INS Kardip	Kamorta Island, A&N	Andaman & Nicobar Command	Naval base for Nicobar group of islands

19. MAJOR AIRPORTS AND AIR FORCE STATIONS

India has 137+ operational airports and 60+ Air Force Stations. Key civilian airports are often co-located with or near strategic IAF bases.

Airport / Air Force Station	Location	Type / Command	Strategic Role
Indira Gandhi International (DEL)	New Delhi	Civilian + IAF Palam	Busiest airport in India; T1, T2, T3 terminals
Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International (BOM)	Mumbai	Civilian	2nd busiest; 2 terminals; T2 integrated terminal
Kempegowda International (BLR)	Bengaluru	Civilian	4th busiest; named after Nadaprabhu Kempegowda
Rajiv Gandhi International (HYD)	Hyderabad	Civilian	GMR-operated; 5th busiest airport
Chennai International (MAA)	Chennai	Civilian + IAF Tambaram (nearby)	Key gateway for South India
Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose International (CCU)	Kolkata	Civilian	Gateway to East India and NE India
Cochin International (COK)	Kochi, Kerala	Civilian	World's first fully solar-powered international airport
Lokpriya Gopinath Bordoloi International	Guwahati, Assam	Civilian	Gateway to Northeast India
Air Force Station Palam	New Delhi	IAF (Western Air Command)	Co-located with IGI; VVIP flight hub
Air Force Station Hindon	Ghaziabad, UP	IAF (WAC)	Largest Asia-Pacific air base; home to transport fleet
Air Force Station Ambala	Haryana	IAF (WAC)	Rafale jets home base; key strike base in NW
Air Force Station Pathankot	Punjab	IAF (WAC)	Forward base; attacked by terrorists in Jan 2016

Airport / Air Force Station	Location	Type / Command	Strategic Role
Air Force Station Adampur	Punjab	IAF (WAC)	Key fighter base; Sukhoi Su-30 MKI
Air Force Station Srinagar	J&K	IAF (WAC)	Forward base; high-altitude operations
Kushok Bakula Rimpochhe Airport / AFS Leh	Ladakh	Civilian + IAF	World's highest commercial airports; critical for Ladakh
Air Force Station Jodhpur	Rajasthan	IAF (SW Air Command)	Key desert warfare base; Exercise Vayu Shakti
Air Force Station Jaisalmer	Rajasthan	IAF (SW Air Command)	Advanced forward base near Pakistan border
Air Force Station Uttarlai	Barmer, Rajasthan	IAF (SW Air Command)	Forward base in Thar desert
Air Force Station Bhuj	Gujarat	IAF (SW Air Command)	Critical western sector base
Air Force Station Naliya	Kutch, Gujarat	IAF (SW Air Command)	Westernmost IAF base; frontline fighter base
Air Force Station Gwalior	MP	IAF (Central Air Command)	Maharaja Madhav Rao Scindia Airport; Jaguar base
Air Force Station Agra	UP	IAF (Central Air Command)	C-17 and IL-76 transport aircraft hub
Air Force Station Yelahanka	Bengaluru	IAF (Training Command)	Hosts biennial Aero India show
Air Force Station Hakimpet	Hyderabad	IAF (Training Command)	Advanced helicopter training
Air Force Station Tambaram	Chennai	IAF (Southern Air Command)	Historic WWII-era base
Air Force Station Thanjavur	Tamil Nadu	IAF (Southern Air Command)	Su-30 MKI base; Bay of Bengal operations
Air Force Station Tezpur	Assam	IAF (Eastern Air Command)	Su-30 MKI base; key NE India base
Air Force Station Jorhat	Assam	IAF (EAC)	Logistic and helicopter base for NE
Air Force Station Chabua	Assam	IAF (EAC)	WWII era; forward base NE India
Air Force Station Hashimara	WB	IAF (EAC)	Near Bhutan tri-junction; sensitive forward base
Air Force Station Car Nicobar	A&N Islands	IAF (A&N Command)	Strategic island base in Indian Ocean

Note: IAF Station Hindon is the largest airbase in Asia-Pacific. AFS Ambala is home to the Rafale fleet (No. 17 Sqn 'Golden Arrows' and No. 101 Sqn 'Falcons'). AFS Yelahanka hosts biennial Aero India.